

benu





CENTURY QUAIL EGG

ginger purée, cream potage of bacon and aromatics
green jus of Napa cabbage
Century quail egg

MUSSEL

poached in plum wine and then glazed
stuffed with sweet potato glass noodle
cucumber, daikon, egg, carrot, kombu

ANCHOVY

toasted sourdough and ssamjang
made with soy beans, garlic, chile, tomatillo

MAINE EEL

grilled eel fillet and grilled spring onion, radish
dehydrated and grilled eel skin, eel bone sauce
dried Sansho pepper, signet marigold leaves

ZUCCHINI BLOSSOM

zucchini blossom “jeon” stuffed with shrimp and pickled ramp
sauce of soy sauce and perilla oil

TOMATO

marinated campari tomato
stuffed with tofu made with reduced soy milk and pine nuts
clarified broth of raw and cooked tomato juice

SPENT GRAIN BREAD

served with cultured butter from Sonoma
orange blossom honey infused with ginseng

XIAO LONG BAO

with supreme soup made of whole chicken, Tennessee country ham and Spanish ham, and dried scallop
homemade soy sauce and vinegar

CHARCOAL BOODLES

handmade charcoal noodles coated with fermented black bean sauce
fresh Regiis Ova white sturgeon caviar and dried caviar
big fin squid, pickled radish, fresh and pickled cucumber, julienned scallion, sesame leaves

LOBSTER

lobster gangjeong with sesame
savoy spinach, butter, 10-year-aged doenjang, and emulsified spinach garlic sauce with soy milk

WOLFE RANCHE QUAIL

roast quail with maple and soy sauce
lettuce, peas, and bacon
creamy white stew of double-boiled quail stock
espuma of butter, dark quail jus

BEEF RIB

beef rib braised with asian pear and beet, then grilled on charcoal
steamed mountain yam, sautéed onion, purée of beet, pear, and beef stock
condiments of chrysanthemum, minari, chives, and soy sauce

OOLONG TEA

heritage beidou, grand scarlet robe, wuyishan, fujian, china

STRAWBERRY & OMIJA

sphere of strawberry sorbet
quenelle of omija, rose and omija juice with olive oil

MILK PUDDING

with caramel of seaweed and Scottish peat

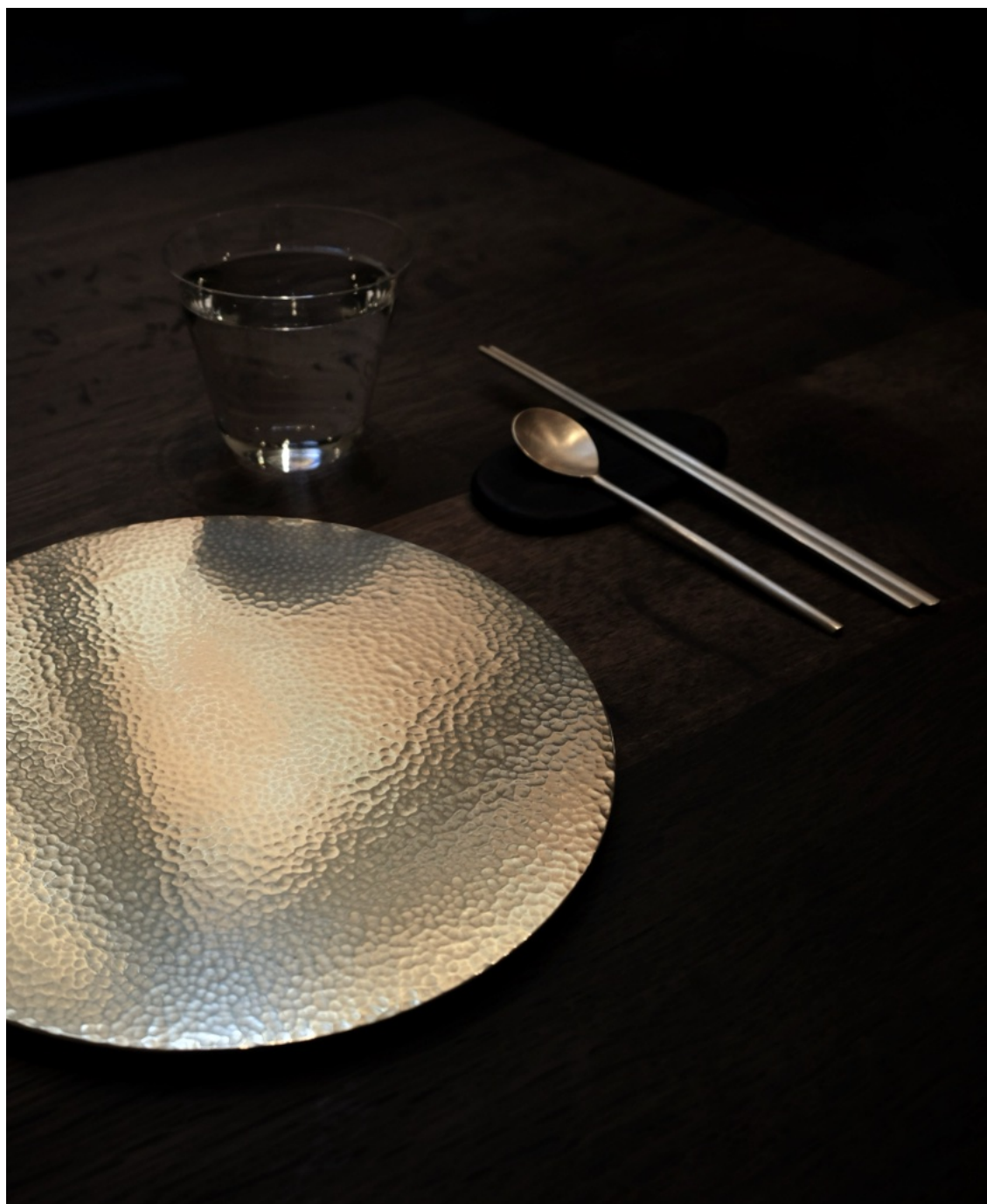
CELEBRATION CAKE

raspberry and chantilly cream

MIGNARDISES

pomelo tart with black sesame and white chocolate
meringue tuile of mint
sikhye infused with pine needle and pine nuts

benu



The greatness of benu needs no elaborate preface. I first heard benu's name in 2017, when I was just beginning to step into the luminous world of fine dining. What captured my imagination was its iconic century quail egg, a dish that seemed to shimmer between worlds. I was drawn to the question: how might a chef, forged in the fires of classical French technique and shaped by Korean heritage, reimagine the essence of Chinese cuisine? I also knew of benu's famed xiao long bao, and as someone born in Hangzhou, arguably the spiritual homeland of xiao long bao, I felt a quiet calling. It wasn't mere curiosity; it was something closer to destiny. And yet, destiny took its time. Eight years would pass before I would finally sit before that long-awaited menu.

For many, the name Corey Lee resonates because of Thomas Keller, and rightly so: Corey stood at the heart of Keller's culinary universe, from The French Laundry, to the birth of Per Se, and eventually back to Yountville, where Keller himself stepped aside and entrusted him as chef de cuisine. Notwithstanding, what to me elevates Corey's story is not just his impeccable résumé, but a more personal thread: his connection to Hong Kong. Long before I ever dined at a Michelin-starred table, I had already heard whispers of Amber. It was the first fine dining restaurant I ever dreamt of, and for reasons I still can't fully explain, it remained the one I most longed to visit in Hong Kong, above all others. In 2023, I finally made that pilgrimage. During the meal, Chef Richard Ekkebus shared a quiet anecdote: Corey Lee had flown in from San Francisco to taste his caviar creation. That moment — intimate, unexpected — further deepened my anticipation for benu.

In 2024, I celebrated my birthday in San Francisco, stealing a glimpse into benu's kitchen, wandering through its garden where barrels lay under the shades, quietly aging the soy sauce. A year later, I returned to the city once more, again for my birthday, but this time, with a reservation as solo diner, proudly. As I sat down at last to the tasting menu I had waited eight years to experience, I felt the quiet weight of fulfillment, like a long thread gently tied.

Benu did not stir much anticipation during the reservation process, and perhaps rightly so. For a restaurant that has held three Michelin stars for over a decade, there is little need to court diners with extra flourishes the way newer establishments might. Yet as I arrive at the restaurant and stand by the familiar glass-paneled kitchen next to the entrance at the appointed hour, I catch a fleeting glimpse of Chef Corey Lee within. In this moment, something settles in me: I know the meal will be extraordinary.



The moment I step inside, a quiet calm washes over me. It is rare, that kind of calm, a quiet that doesn't merely soothe but reassures, as if the very walls whisper of grace earned through time. No food has yet arrived, and yet I already feel cared for. I requested a seat with good light, and they oblige, guiding me to a quiet, spacious corner. Above me, a vast skylight bathes the table in soft daylight, like a benediction cast from above. I love my seat. Glancing around, I notice how the interior, so plain in photographs, reveals a restrained opulence in person. It reminds me of my experience at Park Hyatt Shanghai. Nothing flashy, nothing overstated, and yet everything quietly perfect. The luxury here lives in subtleties, in shadows and textures and silence. It is a refinement that speaks only to those who know how to listen, and that, in itself, makes it feel all the more rare.

The menu copy arrives promptly, just as I prefer. There is a quiet comfort in knowing what lies ahead, far more soothing than the fleeting thrill of a post-meal reveal. A delicate line of happy birthday greets me at the top, followed by the modest phrase "small delicacies." At that moment, I have no idea these two words will soon blossom into six courses, nearly a tasting menu in their own right. I turn to the wine list and select a glass from my beloved niche house, Egly-Ouriet — though it's merely the humbler Les Premices Extra Brut. Crafted from equal parts Pinot Noir, Chardonnay, and Pinot Meunier in Trigny, this champagne is full-bodied and richly textured, its aromas toasty and yeasty, unfolding like a whispered secret. Benu serves it in vintage coupe glass, its broad surface releasing the bouquet swiftly, but with that, the effervescence vanishes, ephemeral as a sigh.

"The thousand-year-old-egg, or pidan, is one of those traditional Asian foods you can't be indifferent about. I love that this polarizing dish exists and always confront diners with benu's beginner's version of it for their first course. It sets an adventurous tone for what's to come. — Corey Lee"

The first to arrive, ushering in the procession of small delicacies, is the long-awaited century egg. Undeniably, it is benu's most iconic creation. As Corey Lee himself has reflected, San Francisco is a city shaped by cultural convergence, and benu draws deeply from that rich, interwoven heritage. Pidān, or century egg, stands as a timeless emblem of Chinese cuisine, steeped in history, memory, and complexity. In a city that harbors the oldest and one of the most storied Chinatowns in America, beginning a tasting menu with this timeless morsel feels nothing short of poetic. The century egg has long posed a challenge for many unfamiliar with Chinese cuisine. Benu's interpretation is far more gentle, almost tender in spirit. Here, the traditional duck egg is replaced with a quail egg, and the curing time is halved from 24 days to just 12. The brine, composed of 5% salt, 4% lye, and 1% pu-erh tea leaves, subtly transforms the flavor, lending the egg a unique, refined depth. After a twelve-day soak, the eggs are rinsed in running, room-temperature water until the stream runs clear. They are then dried, sealed in an airtight bag, and left to age for four weeks at 68 to 77 degrees Fahrenheit. Only then are they considered ready, quietly transformed, patiently waiting.

Yet this is only the beginning. What surrounds the egg is just as essential to its brilliance. Most crucial is a French-style cream potage, which becomes the dish's flavor foundation. Butter, bacon, napa cabbage, sliced onion, a touch of cayenne, chicken stock, and cream are simmered gently for 45 minutes and then puréed into a velvety, warm broth. This potage wraps the dish in richness, offering warmth and depth without overwhelming the delicate flavors of the egg. It soothes rather than shouts. Then comes the brightness: young ginger, pickled in champagne vinegar, scattered like tiny notes of acidity. There is a jade-green, almost translucent napa cabbage jus, and finally, a whipped ginger cream made from fresh ginger juice, cream, xanthan gum, and Versawhip. To serve, the cured quail egg is boiled briefly, shocked in ice, then peeled and halved. Each half is seasoned with salt and a dash of pickled ginger juice. A small mound of chopped pickled ginger rests at the center of the bowl, topped with a cloud of ginger cream. The egg is placed gently on top, and finally, the hot potage is poured. In this single bite, Corey Lee weaves together an astonishingly layered flavor profile. He folds the essence of French cuisine into the soul of Chinese tradition. The potage, in its warmth and subtle depth, recalls the silken comfort and soothing taste of Cantonese congee, while the compositions on ginger evoke the sliced ginger often found within congee. In this way, the dish becomes a kind of tribute — a traditional century egg and pork congee, reimagined with grace, restraint, and reverence.



In traditional Korean cuisine, banchan is indispensable. A simple word that can eventually reveal an entire table of small dishes. Conventionally, all the banchan are served at once. In Korean fine dining, this tradition takes on different forms: at more traditional establishments like Jungsik in New York, which recently earned its third Michelin star, five or six banchan arrive together. More contemporary restaurants, such as Atomix, have chosen to de-emphasize the concept, instead creating a seamless progression from smaller dishes to mains.

At benu, where fusion lies at the heart of the philosophy, the name “small delicacies” may be a hidden nod to banchan. Here, each small dish is served individually, with far more complexity in both form and preparation than the humble spirit of its inspiration might suggest. After the fascinating Chinese century egg as the first course, the next small delicacy leans more Korean in spirit: a single, jewel-like mussel. This is one of benu’s most beloved small bites and has been a fixture on the menu for years. Interestingly, however, it does not appear in the 2015 Benu cookbook published by Phaidon, suggesting it was created sometime afterward.

Now, the acclaimed dish arrives as a single, perfect mouthful. The mussel itself, being meticulously picked, is poached for twelve hours in plum wine, then gently glazed. Within, it is stuffed with sweet potato glass noodles. Firm, neatly bundled, and surprisingly substantial. Covering the noodles are translucent, vibrant sheets of vegetable: cucumber, daikon, egg, carrot, kombu, each bringing its own hue but a rather uniform texture. From a certain angle, the dish even resembles a wide, laughing mouth filled with psychedelically colored teeth. A whimsical detail that does not detract from its elegance.

Carefully lifting the entire mussel with flat Korean metal chopsticks and placing it into my mouth, I find the mussel quite a revelation. Despite the long poach, the mussel retains its structure, tender yet toothsome, sweet and briny, with the clarity of something nearly raw. The plum wine imparts a subtle brightness, lightly tart and refreshingly sweet, lending both gloss and lift to the mussel. Don’t be fooled by its size: the bundle of glass noodles is dense, and once it begins to expand slightly from moisture, I notice a faint resistance as it unfolds on the palate. This minor tension slightly interrupts the otherwise seamless texture of the mussel and vegetable ribbons, just enough to pull me out of the moment, if only for a second. Still, the bite remains striking, balanced, thoughtful, and unmistakably benu.

A small incident unfolds just after I am seated at Benu. I receive a message from Kiln, the restaurant I’m scheduled to visit the following day. Regretfully, they inform me that I am the only guest made a reservation for tomorrow evening, and for that reason, they must sadly cancel my reservation. They kindly offer to help transfer my booking to another restaurant and ask that I call or text back as soon as possible. I phone them right away, and after a brief exchange, we tentatively agree on moving my reservation to Sons & Daughters, though it’s not yet finalized. I’ve never encountered anything quite like this. My first reaction is worry, that the stress and distraction might cloud my experience at benu. However, miraculously, it doesn’t. My mood remains light, even cheerful. And I think that says everything about benu’s brilliance: the ambiance, the service, the careful pacing, and the graceful explanation with which each dish is presented. All of it calms me, holds me, and keeps me present. By far as I reach the mussel, only the second dish of the evening, a quiet satisfaction has already taken root. The tone is set, and I know I’m in good hands.



Following the mussel, two more seafood-centered delicacies make their entrance, one anchored by anchovy, the other by eel. As the first is placed before me, I'm overcome by a feeling both intimate and uncanny. The architecture, fish delicately poised upon bread, is hardly revolutionary, yet its quiet elegance stirs something deeper. There is a whisper of sushi in its composition: seafood resting gently on a carbohydrate foundation, mirroring its silhouette and spirit.

In countless French-Japanese fusion restaurants, this motif reappears. Think of sea urchin on toast, a signature at the original Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare in New York, now reimagined as César, or Saison in San Francisco. Even Birdsong offers its own thoughtful rendition along similar lines. But here at Benu, Corey turns to anchovy for inspiration. And fittingly so, the last anchovy fishery in the United States stands just beyond these city harbors. In this creation, there is a sense of place and a quiet reverence.

At the base sits a piece of toasted sourdough, though whether it is toasted or fried is up for debate. The server calls it toasted; Corey, in an earlier Instagram post, says fried. The delicate sheet of paper folded beneath it, in the style of Japanese tempura blotting paper, seems to hint at oil, perhaps suggesting the latter. Either way, it holds the bread, lightly crisp and golden. Atop the bread is Benu's iconic tomato ssamjang, though tonight, it is renditioned as a tomatillo ssamjang. Corey once wrote, "Tomato ssamjang is one of my favorite original Benu sauces." It is a sauce with history here. Traditionally, ssamjang is a thick, spicy Korean paste made with fermented soybeans, gochujang, garlic, scallion, and sesame oil. Benu's version evolves in the form of soybeans, garlic, chile, and tonight, tomatillo. Compared to tomatoes, tomatillos bring sharper acidity, a vegetal brightness, even a hint of citrus. But in a sauce this subtle, the differences whisper rather than shout. Then comes the anchovy: two glistening fillets laid on top of the sauce, garnished with fine threads of scallion. Curiously, the scallion is not chopped into medallions as often seen, but sliced lengthwise, reminiscent of Cantonese cuisine. Another quiet gesture, perhaps, toward the dish's many cultural echoes.

I lift the composition, so seemingly simple, and take a bite. Stunned. A deep, round flavor blooms in my mouth, unexpected and whole. The textures and flavors meld seamlessly, a harmony rather than a solo. The bread is crisp but never hard, never greasy. The ssamjang is rich yet bright, its savoriness lifting rather than weighing down. Paired with the anchovy, it conjures the creaminess and sweetness of high-grade uni from Hokkaido. The fish itself is not assertive like a soloist, but its dense texture, profound umami, and generous unctuousness speak clearly through the whole amalgamation. In this single bite, nothing feels out of place. Every element folds into the next with elegance. Complexity finds clarity. Balance is absolute.





The next roll, centered around eel, draws even more deeply from Japanese influence. Tonight's eel hails from Maine, shaped into a slender cylinder of elegant restraint. Its outermost layer is eel skin, dehydrated and then grilled, chewy yet supple, as though it has undergone some magical process of gelification. Beneath lies a single translucent sheet of radish, wrapping around the core of grilled eel fillet entwined with tender spring onion. The roll is served with a rather condensed sauce made from eel bones, evoking the soul of unagi kabayaki with remarkable fidelity. Sprinkled on top is dried sansho pepper, lending its fragrant tingle, and micro leaves of signet marigold adds a gentle visual flourish.

Unlike the rich, lacquered flavors of traditional unagi kabayaki or unagidon, the seasoning here is restrained, allowing the natural umami of the ingredients to shine. Especially the fillet within, delicate and juicy, bearing a lightness reminiscent of Chinese-style steamed eel. From the eel bone sauce to the use of sansho pepper, this is unmistakably a reinterpretation, a thoughtful reimagining of the Japanese kabayaki tradition, expressed through the language of Benu.

The next course arrives, revealing itself as a zucchini blossom, resting at the center of the plate in a rather pristine form. On the menu, it is described as prepared in the style of Korean jeon, delicately stuffed with shrimp mousse and pickled ramp. In Korean tradition, jeon refers to savory fritters or pancakes, often made from vegetables, seafood, or meat, dipped in flour and egg white batter, and gently pan-fried to a golden crisp. In my memory, jeon is something humble and rustic: a jumble of ingredients bound together in a comforting pancake. But this blossom speaks in a different register. With its graceful form and layered composition, it calls to mind not jeon, but the Cantonese jin yeung sam bo (Three Stuffed Treasures). The resemblance further deepens with a silken pool of soy sauce and perilla oil beneath the flower. Aromatic and glistening, guiding the dish unmistakably into Cantonese terrain.

This method of encasing ingredients in a light batter appears across culinary traditions. Whether it's the Cantonese jin yeung sam bo or tempura in Japanese dining, there's a crucial distinction: in those dishes, the exterior is almost invisible. And that, I believe, makes all the difference. In both jin yeung sam bo and tempura, the coating is never shouting, it provides important texture but at the same time recedes into the background, allowing the purity of the primary ingredient to shine. We taste eggplant, bell pepper, and many other ingredients, not a thick, greasy chunk of batter. We savor their natural forms and nuanced flavors, each bite a quiet testament to respect and restraint in technique. In contrast, a traditional jeon is a mingling of elements, less about the essence of a singular ingredient, more about the hearty fusion it becomes. It reads as something closer to a gluten bomb, bold and unrestrained, lively in its heat and oil and layered flavor.

That is why, despite the menu calling this a jeon, I find myself drawn to the comparison with jin yeung sam bo. This is a jeon distilled and refined, a restrained echo of something once rustic. Beneath its gossamer-thin shell lies the most delicate expression of the zucchini blossom itself: tender, supple, and slightly herbal. The flavor is mild, almost whisper-soft, like that of a young squash, but carrying a faint sweetness and verdant note that speaks of the plant's tender core. Its texture, velvet-like and ephemeral, is elevated by the lightly crisp exterior, which manages to be elastic yet impossibly airy. The stem reveals itself to be a quiet treasure, the closer it grows to the squash, the deeper its sweetness and vegetal depth. And nestled within, the shrimp mousse: soft, savory, and subtly briny, a clear homage to the Cantonese tradition of filling and folding. Here, what follows a single bite is a crescendo of textures and flavors. First, the delicate outer shell, slightly sticky, with a yielding elasticity that dissolves almost on contact. Then, the blossom itself, moist, silken, unmistakably floral. Finally, the shrimp mousse, elegant in flavor, light in body, gently sweet, and restrained. Each layer reveals itself in turn, unfolding on a linear melody like a fine opus.



Soon, the small delicacies draw to a close. If the last three dishes lean ever so slightly toward modesty in visual presentation, the final offering ascends to a rare summit where aesthetics and flavor reach equal heights. It is also the only fully vegetarian dish among the set, featuring a marinated Campari tomato, radiating like a rare ruby.

At its heart is a filling of tofu, made from reduced soy milk steeped with pine nuts. Creamy, delicate, and refined. The tomato rests in a clarified broth of raw and cooked tomato juices, served in a handcrafted metal bowl. Natural light spills from above, catching the curves of the tomato, illuminating its ruby body until it gleams with an inner glow. The clear surface of the broth mirrors this radiance, shimmering like mountain spring water, while the hammered metal bowl casts soft, iridescent reflections that amplify the elegance. It is almost too beautiful to disturb.

And yet, the kitchen has already done the delicate work of halving the fruit. As I gently pull the halves apart, I glimpse the silken core of the pristine infusion of tofu nestled within. Not long ago, this core was still liquid, set gently inside the tomato to rest and slowly solidify. This is a dish that evokes the quiet beauty of oriental Zen—the essence of shojin ryori in Japan, or the refined vegetarian temple cuisines of China or Korea. Though visually resplendent, it never feels ostentatious. The pine nut-infused soy milk lends a subtle nuttiness to the tofu, but the overall flavor remains restrained, tranquil, pure.



I take a bite. The first sensation that strikes me is the tomato. Succulent, juicy, but not in any vulgar way. This is not an explosion of juice, but a gentle yielding: the flesh melts under the slightest pressure, releasing a slow, crystalline stream of sweetness. It is like drinking from a hidden spring in the forest, the clarity of its flavor so pure it stuns me. There is no trace of artifice, just the honest, vibrant sweetness of nature at its most serene. Then comes the tofu. Tender, smooth, subtly nutty, perfectly harmonized with the tomato. The two join effortlessly, like elements of the same landscape. Though light and ethereal, the tomato and tofu duo resonates deeply, it nourishes something far beyond hunger.

I then sip the broth. It is delicate as rosewater, floral and serene, as though composed of petals and silence. A single drop holds more grace than words can catch. This is more than just a sip of tomato broth, it is a multi-functional nectar. Bright and pure, it carries a floral sweetness laced with sunlit acidity, gently awakening my palate. It is an *apéritif* in essence. At the same time, it is soft and graceful, serene and soothing, washing away the lingering traces of the courses before. In this sense, it becomes a palate cleanser.

And with that, the small delicacies segment draws to a close: it began with a bold and daring thousand-year egg, and ends with the quiet elegance of a single tomato. As a sequence, it feels like a self-contained play, complete and satisfying. But within the broader arc of the meal, it also serves as a perfect overture, an act of gentle awakening.



Before the main courses begin, a tall jar of honey arrives at my table. Thanks to some preview I did beforehand, I immediately recognize this as the bread course. Consequently, a piece of cultured butter from Sonoma County is presented before me in the shape of a honeycomb, along with a warm piece of bread wrapped in a white cloth. The server explains that the honey is orange blossom honey, meticulously infused with ginseng. If someone find it surprising to see such a classic European duo of bread and butter in an Asian dining degustation, the word ginseng will instantly eliminate the concern. Of course, Corey Lee hasn't forgotten to weave in threads of his cultural heritage.

For most of us raised in Asia, Ginseng is a flavor we've known all our lives. It is an ingredient that lives in the liminal space between food and medicine.

In the philosophy of Chinese 「医食同源」 or in Japanese 「いしょくどうげん (Ishokudo-gen)」 — the belief that food and medicine share the same roots— flavor and medical function are never truly separate. This perspective runs deep in oriental cultures. Ginseng is one of its most prized ingredients, renowned for boosting vitality, strengthening immunity, and enhancing energy. It's widely believed that the finest ginseng comes from Korea, and Corey Lee has grown up with it in many forms—fresh, dried, powdered, steeped into tea or soup.

As children, many of us recoil from the medicinal bitterness of ginseng. But over time, as one's relationship with flavor deepens, a different truth will emerges. Used with care, balanced with savoriness and a touch of sweetness, ginseng reveals its more poetic facets: hints of ripe melon, Christmas spice, and young ginger. At Benu, this philosophy is distilled into one quiet, exquisite gesture: ginseng infused in orange blossom honey, aged for 14 days at room temperature, then drizzled atop cultured butter from Sonoma, and spread over warm spent grain bread. The result is refined and long-lingering, an overture of subtlety and memory.





The first official course listed on the menu is xiao long bao, a name well known to many of Benu's devoted fans. In fact, this dish has become something of a signature at benu, appearing on the menu for over a decade, dating back to the restaurant's earliest days when Corey Lee first founded it. Interestingly, the use of its pinyin name has always drawn particular attention from Chinese diners like myself. As someone from Hangzhou, where xiao long bao thrives, I approach this dish with both high expectations and deep curiosity: how might a Korea-born, French-trained chef interpret such a classic? Would it be an homage to tradition, or a reinvention in his own creative voice?

This dish appeared in benu's 2015 cookbook, where it took the form of a lobster coral xiao long bao. Though I never had the chance to try that earlier version, I find myself even more intrigued by the present incarnation, in which Corey returns to the roots of the dish, presenting a pork-filled dumpling with a rich, supreme soup made of whole chicken, Tennessee country ham and Spanish ham, and dried scallop. The benu cookbook offers insight into the thoughtful process behind this dish's creation. As Corey himself notes, there is no single standard for xiao long bao, the variations across China are as numerous as its cities and villages. Each place has developed its own version, subtly or significantly different from the next. In that spirit, what Corey has crafted is not a replication, but a reflection, one that honors the tradition while quietly speaking in his own dialect of flavor.

“In 2013, I visited Nanxiang, a small town in northern Shanghai, where xiao long bao were invented at Guyi Garden restaurant. The dumplings were small, wrapped in a rather thick, unleavened dough, and didn't have much liquid in them- they were juicy rather than gushing with soup. Although tasty, they were very different from the ones I was trying to make. I suppose, like all foods, there is no perfect xiao long bao. My search, I realized, would have no real end. It's just about preference. I guess that's what chefs do — pursue standards that exist only in our heads and devote our lives to finer points that few people notice. But I'd like to believe that people do notice in the end. Perhaps not each step, but everything we work to achieve can collectively elevate food to something greater than just the sum of its parts. I really hope that's true because it's that belief that keeps us going. — Corey Lee ”

There are generally two kinds of xiao long bao: leavened and unleavened. As someone from Hangzhou, I can only accept the latter as the true form. This isn't just regional pride speaking. The unleavened version, to me, reflects a higher level of craftsmanship and elegance, capturing the very essence of what xiao long bao should be. For me, three qualities define the ideal dumpling. First, the skin. It is the first thing the diner sees, and the greatest technical challenge. It should be as thin as veil, almost translucent, yet strong enough to cradle the soup within. When lifted, the bottom should dip ever so slightly, a quiet marvel of tension and grace. On the palate, the skin should yield gently. Present, but never overpowering. Second, the soup. More than the meat, it is the soul of the dumpling. It should be rich, umami, and addictive. When the dumpling is gently opened, the broth pool into the spoon, inviting an eager sip while still steaming hot. Finally, the meat core. It is expected to be tender yet cohesive, never mushy, never dry, offering a balanced counterpoint to the soup and skin.

Xiao long bao has now become an international dish. In the benu cookbook, Corey Lee mentions visiting Din Tai Fung, the world-renowned chain specializing in xiao long bao. Ironically, if you visit a Din Tai Fung in the states, you might be surprised to find that, behind the glass window of the open kitchen, the dumplings are always made by Mexican cooks. Of course, they follow techniques developed by legendary artisans, but to many Chinese diners, those dumplings, while technically perfect, feel soulless. That's not to say they taste bad. On the contrary, they often surpass many "authentic" versions found in China. Just as chef Thomas Keller might make better pasta than many Italian nonne, Corey Lee has shown that he can craft xiao long bao with more finesse than many Chinese chefs. Corey's version of xiao long bao not only meets but exceeds my highest standards. I especially appreciate this more traditional pork version as it allows me to judge it against the most classic criteria. And I can honestly say: it's one of the best xiao long bao I've ever had. Yet if you ask me where to go for xiao long bao, my heart will always belong to the humble bao found near home. They may be less refined, but they speak to something deeper. That's how food written into your DNA works: beyond taste, it carries memory, emotion, and a story only you can fully understand.



If the dumpling wrapper in xiao long bao is too delicate to qualify the dish as a true carbohydrate course, then the next offering has no such excuse. Cold noodle, a staple of Korean cuisine, reborn in the hands of Corey Lee. I have heard that no one ever leaves Benu still hungry, and now I understand why: three consecutive carbohydrate-based dishes mark the beginning of the menu's core. More than just imaginative and flawlessly executed, they offer true substance. A hallmark of a satisfying Asian meal.

Here, I am served handmade charcoal noodles coated in fermented black bean sauce, paired with big-fin squid, pickled radish, fresh and pickled cucumber, julienned scallion, and sesame leaves. At the center of this composition are two forms of caviar: fresh Regiis Ova white sturgeon caviar and its dried counterpart. It takes both daring and precision to place something as luxurious as caviar atop something as humble as noodles. Imagine the criticism if the pairing failed, if the caviar overwhelmed the dish, or worse, felt out of place. And then there's the dried caviar, a move bordering on audacious. Who dares to dry such a prestigious ingredient? Does it improve the flavor? If not, the backlash would surely be swift, condemning the waste of something so precious.

One might ask: is this a noodle dish, or a caviar dish? It's neither, or perhaps both. The noodles serve as a unifying canvas, supporting rather than starring, while the caviar is indeed honored, presented in two thoughtful, contrasting forms. Yet the identity of the dish resists categorization. It's not a statement of dominance, but of harmony, delivered through a quiet yet noble sensibility.

There's a striking visual unity here. The charcoal noodles, black bean sauce, caviar, and even the bowl itself dwell in deep shades of black, evoking a mysterious abyss. This darkness is gently offset by the bright greens of the fresh vegetables, offering a breath of life and a glimmer of hope. Flavor-wise, the dish sings with oceanic umami—from the caviar, from the squid—all layered over the comforting earthiness of the noodles and black bean base. The balance allows bolder ingredients to shine without overpowering the whole.

Atop it all, the dried caviar is shaved over the dish like grey snow. A quiet, almost imperceptible gesture. Its flavor is delicate, nearly undetectable. If anyone questions the use of such a costly ingredient for such subtle effect, perhaps that is precisely the point: to forget the price, and attend only to the taste and texture. If caviar were inexpensive, no one would question such presence. The value, then, lies not in extravagance, but in restraint.





Now as I step into the climax act of the gastronomy performance, three main courses make their entrance, first a lobster, then a quail, and finally a beef course. It has almost become a convention for multi-course tasting menus to unfold in this sequence: seafood, then poultry, and eventually beef or lamb. Presented in a distinctly Korean metal bowl rest pieces of lobster gangjeong, lightly tossed with baby spinach. Here, the lobster is not showcased as a whole tail or in meticulously aligned medallions; instead, it appears in casual, irregular chunks, giving the whole a cozy, home-style character, which is further sublimated by the choice of dinnerware.

Gangjeong refers to a type of dish where various ingredients are deep-fried and coated in a sweet, sticky sauce. It is supposed to be, like many traditional Asian dishes, a comfort food dish. Corey's interpretation preserves this sense of modesty. The lobster pieces are coated in a fried crust—likely a blend of flour and cornstarch—though the texture leans a bit too mushy for my taste. They are finished with sesame seeds and paired with a rich creamy medley: butter, an emulsified spinach-garlic-soy-milk sauce, and a ten-year-aged doenjang, a Korean fermented soybean paste known for its salty, earthy savor.

The overall style of the dish closely echoes that of the celebrated Cantonese typhoon-shelter-style lobster. Yet, rather than chasing the explosive crunch or garlic-laced style of its Cantonese counterpart, this rendition retreats inward, almost contemplative. It feels like a memory of the original version rather than its embodiment, it is a quieter, more reflective echo. Without doubt, the resemblance to typhoon-shelter-style lobster is unmistakable. The flavors are rounded rather than sharp, the textures subdued rather than contrasting. In this sense, the dish reads as a technical reinterpretation filtered through Korean sensibilities, offering an intriguing cultural hybrid even if it stops short of fully capturing the punch of the original.



It seems that birds are always the centerpiece in a gastronomical show scene. In Chinese restaurants, Peking duck is carved tableside, a ceremonial moment of precision and pride. In French dining, whole roasted duck adorned with herbs and flowers are often brought out for display. In more traditional settings, you might witness a *canard à la presse*, where duck is pressed for its blood-rich jus, or a *Volaille de Bresse en Vessie*, dramatically unveiled. Such presentations are rarely afforded to seafood or beef, perhaps only when a whole salt-crusted fish is cracked open, or when a prized cut of Miyazaki wagyu is reverently placed in a wooden box, accompanied by its identity card like a passport of prestige.

In my recent dining experiences, the bird course has consistently marked the pinnacle of the meal. Perhaps it's a personal bias, or perhaps it's the natural result of exceptional ingredients and thoughtful execution. One detail worth noting: every memorable quail I've had—from Maude to Vespertine to Benu—has come from Wolfe Ranch. Tonight reaffirmed that Wolfe Ranch quail is beyond reproach.

At Benu, the quail is glazed in maple and soy sauce before sent to the oven. The maple lends a lustrous finish; the soy sauce, a deep umami whisper, stirs something memorable and instinctive in every Asian palate. The accompanying elements, namely lettuce, peas, and bacon, bridge French and Asian traditions. The creamy white stew made from double-boiled quail stock echoes the earlier potage of century quail egg, creating a resonant through-line in the meal. It also recalls the style of Japanese French, mastered by chefs like César Ramirez, whose dishes at Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare often feature similar layers of refinement.

A delicate butter espuma adds modern lightness, a subtle reminder of benu's contemporary edge. Meanwhile, the dark quail jus—rich, concentrated, classically French—is lifted by a subtle note of soy sauce, once again merging Oriental and Occidental in quiet harmony.

In terms of overall flavor, the dish is deeply satisfying with a mellow, rounded profile, especially for an Asian diner, who may feel a nostalgic pull in every bite. The texture of the bird is perfectly executed, tender yet structured. And yet, if I'm to be fully honest, something is missing: a final spark, a note of astonishment. The dish is complete, but anticipates transcendence.



Is there any fine-dining French restaurant that would dare to serve boeuf bourguignon as the main course? Not to my recollection. For Asian restaurants, especially Korean or Chinese, such a practice of fully cooking the beef seems more justified, for both Korean and Chinese cuisines enjoy beef served in this way. Short rib is also the most preferable among all the fine cuts, for it has the perfect balance of fat that not only renders an extremely soft texture but also releases a large amount of umami through its unctuousness. Short ribs also always work well with rich sauces.

The very last savory “shout” of the menu reveals itself to be centered on a delicate cut of beef rib braised with Asian pear and beet, then grilled over charcoal. Such preparation immediately stirred my nostalgic emotion for galbi-jjim. The rib is bathed in a condensed sauce made from a purée of beet, pear, and beef stock, further elevating the mellow, fruit-leading sweetness of the composition. On top, a piece of steamed mountain yam is placed, hiding a touch of sautéed onion underneath. The addition of yam, apart from its unique taste, perhaps also echoes its medicinal significance. Yam is essential in Asian dietary culture and has long been recognized for its medicinal properties; and considering Corey’s belief that food and medicine share the same roots, it is no surprise to see the yam’s appearance.

Aside from the main dish, there is also a small tray of condiments — a classical Chinese act. In this small plate, I find chrysanthemum, minari, and chives, all finely chopped and immersed in a soy-sauce bath. The condiment is clearly minari-dominated, lending a fresh, grassy, and peppery aroma to counter the richness of the rib. The overall flavor profile is far from mind-blowing, yet it is exactly this feeling of settling and relief that makes it especially precious.



“Would you like some tea or coffee?” This line of questioning is almost ritualistic in fine dining rooms, inevitably posed once dessert approaches. Thus, it is somewhat surprising that, at Benu, a tea list is presented as part of the overall menu experience. The tasting menu itself does not offer a tea pairing option, yet highlighting tea during the dessert courses feels like a more thoughtful and deliberate gesture. I opt for a pot of Heritage Beidou Grand Scarlet Robe oolong from Wuyishan, for its deep, comforting aroma. Dark, mineral, and soothing to both mind and palate. Another charming surprise is the delicate birthday cake the restaurant prepared for me, delivered in an ornate music box. As I twist the handle, a lilting birthday melody begins to play, revealing a meticulously crafted raspberry chantilly cream cake nestled inside. The cake itself is exquisite in appearance, anyone familiar with the precision demanded by French pastry would be dazzled by its refinement and presentation. The flavor, however, lacks an equivalent touch of magic.





One curious aspect of East Asian dining culture is the relative de-emphasis on dessert. What typically follows a meal is either seasonal fruit or a simple sweet based on rice, wheat, or glutinous flour. For example, Chinese sweet rice cake, Korean sweet pancakes, or Japanese mochi. As a result, I often find myself craving something more substantial in sweetness after a traditional East Asian meal.

In previous tasting menus curated by Korean chefs, I have encountered different strategies. At Jungsik, the experience concludes with a fully French-style pastry; at Jua, the chefs return to tradition with the classic Korean sweet pancake, *danhobak*. Yet neither approach fully convinces me. One lacks the cultural resonance, the other the finesse expected of a modern fine dining dessert. Atomix, however, offers a more compelling solution: first a seasonal sorbet of young green plum, then a burdock ice cream accented with black truffle. These desserts deliver both technical refinement and a clear expression of the chef's heritage.

Similarly, at Benu, I find the two desserts persuasive in their own right. Despite their relatively modest portions, they bring the meal to an elegant and satisfying close.

The first dessert features a sphere of strawberry sorbet alongside a quenelle of omija sorbet. Omija, a remarkably expressive fruit that carries all five tastes: sweet, salty, umami, bitter, and sour, offers a concentrated burst of flavor that immediately captivates my senses with its balance and intensity. Common in China and Korea yet still unfamiliar to most Western palates, omija is far more intriguing than strawberry in this composition. In fact, I find myself wishing it had taken center stage. Still, the strawberry's sweetness and acidity create a shared register that allows the two fruits to coexist and bridge one another. The addition of rose to the omija not only lends a lighter, more buoyant texture to sorbets that might otherwise feel somewhat flat, but also introduces a delicate floral note that, together with the olive oil, produces a soothing, harmonious finish. The use of olive oil may seem counterintuitive, yet its rare suaveness rounds out the dessert, binding its various elements into perfect harmony.

The second dessert is more of a fusion of Japanese and French temperament. French cuisine has had a tremendous impact on Japan since the last century, and it has flourished remarkably there, arguably better than anywhere else in the world. Some even say it has grown to surpass France itself. Whether better or not, French cuisine in Japan has evolved into something distinctly its own, often referred to as Japanese French cuisine. The milk pudding is a clear indication of this, curated with a light texture and remarkable finesse. Here, a gently quivering outer layer encapsulates an almost liquid inner core. The milk that is used here is from Monterey, where cows are fed with spring grass, hence the subtle herbaceous taste. The sauce that surrounds the pudding is revealed to be a duo of seaweed caramel and Scottish peat done to a level beyond marvel. The seaweed introduces an oceanic umami that counters the condensed sweetness of the caramel, while the peat, with its fiery and dark aura, further deepens the composition with a sophisticated touch of earthy smokiness. This addition of peat not only echoes the idea of fusion but also reflects how deeply the Japanese appreciate Scottish whisky.



A trio of mignardise is finally presented, concluding the gastronomic journey with a sense of refreshment, expressed through three distinct gestures. The first is a pomelo tart with black sesame and white chocolate. The sesame and the white chocolate, as supporting elements, stay deliberately muted, allowing the pomelo's gentle acidity and quiet juiciness to define the bite. Compared to oranges, pomelo reveals a character that is less bright yet more cleansing, almost meditative, setting a perfect zen tone for the coda. Next comes a Sikhye — a Korean dessert drink known for its subtle barley malt flavor — infused with pine needle and pine nuts. The pine elements extend the same meditative calm, deepening the coda's quiet resonance. The final mignardise, a mint meringue tuile, offers an exceptionally delicate texture, though the mint's intensity borders on disruptive, its burst of excitement slightly unsettling the calm established so far. Soon after the meal, I am ushered into the kitchen and warmly greeted by chef Corey Lee himself. As I step out of the restaurant, the barrels come into view once more, as if all these years of anticipation had finally distilled themselves into this moment of joy.

